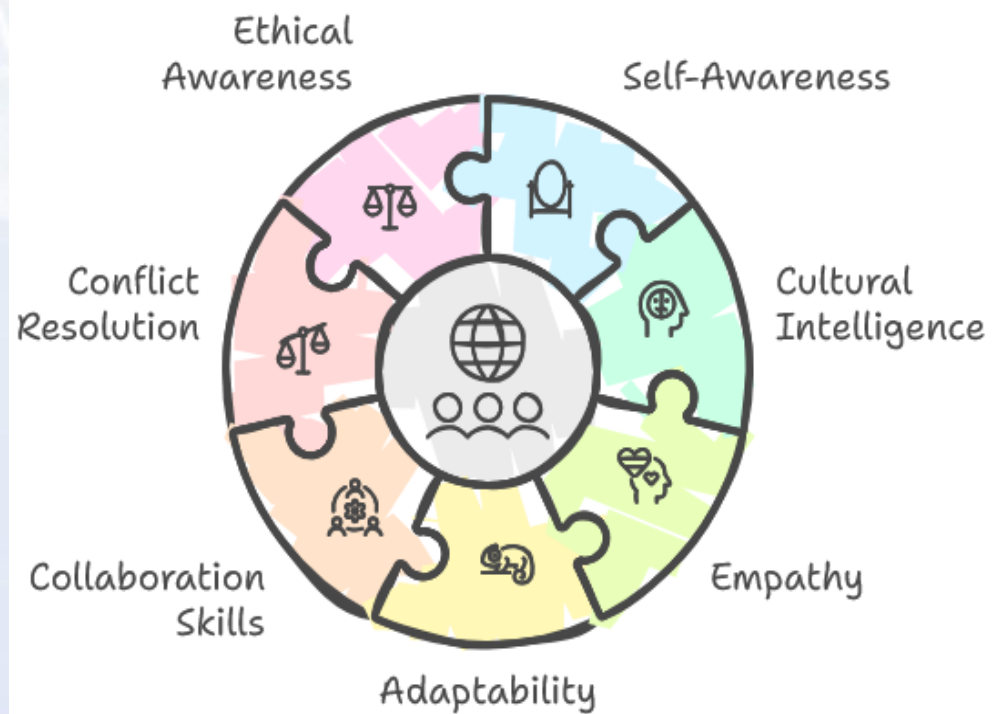




Prof. Dr.-Ing. Lamyia Abdullah Lamyia.Abdullah@provadis-hochschule.de

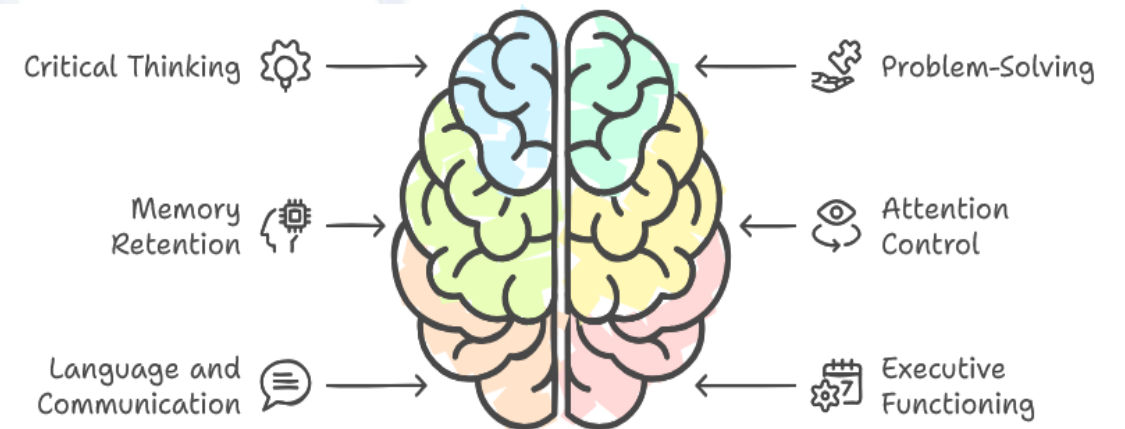
Interkulturelle Kommunikation und heterogene Teams

Lecture Notes – 02: Self-awareness & Communication

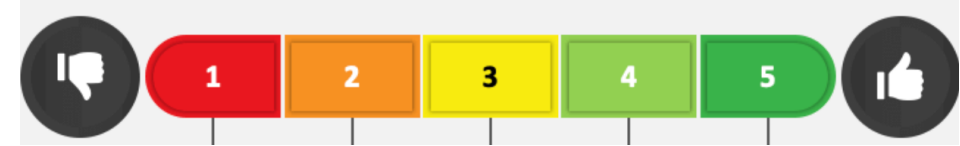


Human Competence

Cognitive Competence



Cognitive Competence Assessment Criteria



Each **criterion** can be rated on a **scale of 1 (low) to 5 (high)**.

Critical Thinking

- Ability to break down complex problems into smaller parts
- Makes logical, structured decisions

Pattern Recognition

- Identifies trends and connections in data or ideas
- Sees relationships others may overlook

Problem-Solving

- Proposes effective solutions
- Thinks creatively when facing challenges

Open-Mindedness

- Considers different perspectives before deciding
- Accepts constructive feedback

Self-Reflection

- Evaluates own thinking and decision-making
- Learns from past experiences

Decision-Making Under Uncertainty

- Stays calm and rational when outcomes are unclear
- Makes decisions even with limited information



Exercise [15 mins] Group Instructions

- Prepare a Practical **Example** of **criterion assessment** in your own words
- Add **one more criterion** for your group if it feels something is missing

Cognitive Competence, How do you rate yourself?



Critical Thinking

- Ability to break down complex problems into smaller parts
- Makes logical, structured decisions

Pattern Recognition

- Identifies trends and connections in data or ideas
- Sees relationships others may overlook

Problem-Solving

- Proposes effective solutions
- Thinks creatively when facing challenges

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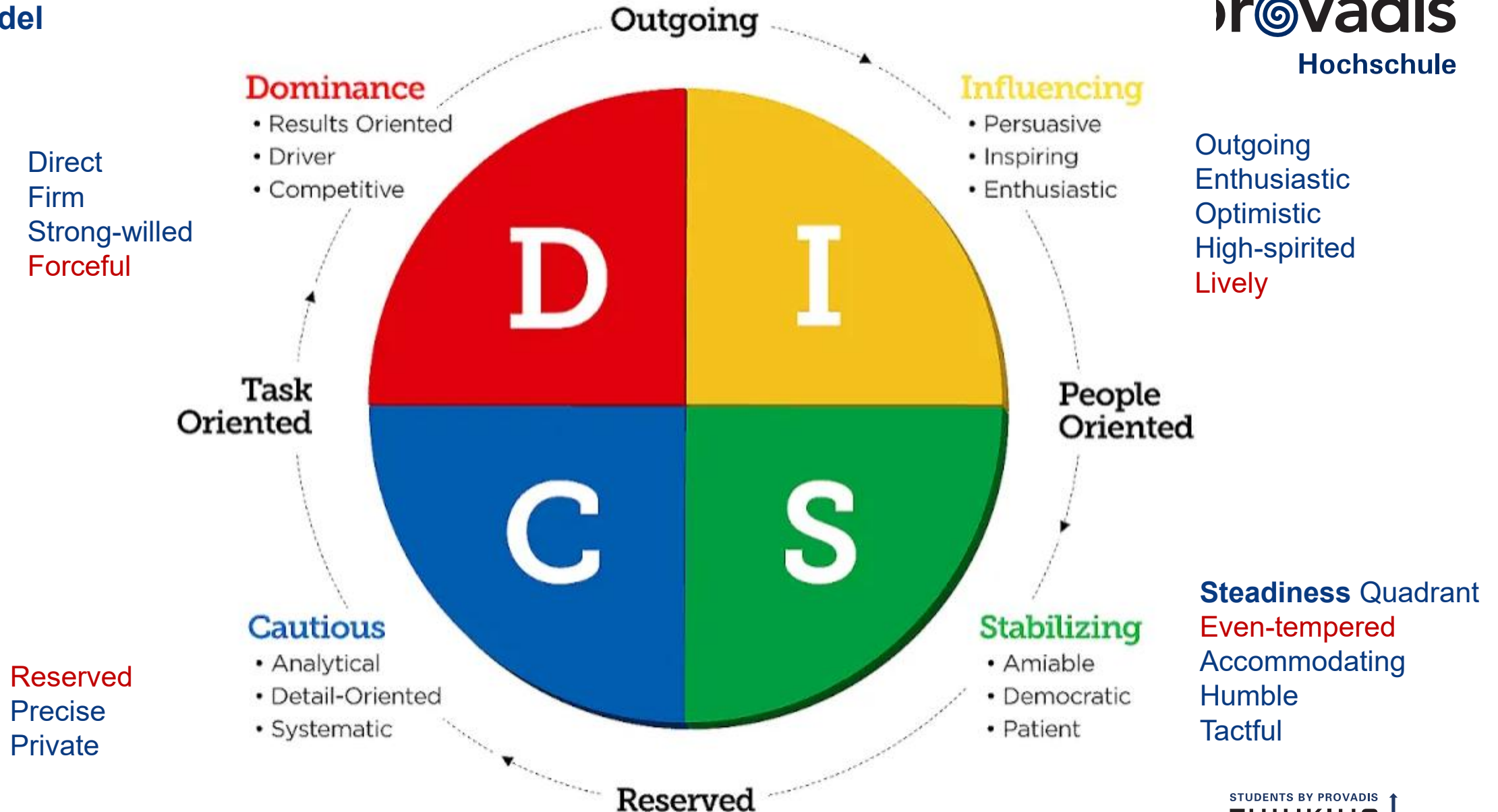
Groups and individual work . groups of 3~6 people

1. Pick **1 Criterion** for each Skill
2. **Individual work**: self-Assessment **[10 mins]**
3. **Overall view** in the **group** –
Assess the **Team competences** **[10 mins]**
4. **Discuss** your results – with others **[10 mins]**

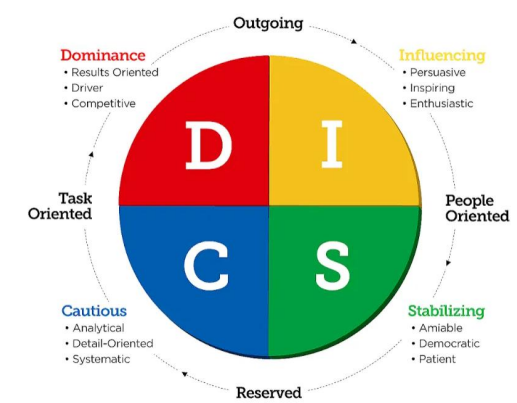
Criteria	Criterion	Self Rating (1–5)	Group Rating (1–5)	Practical Example
Critical Thinking				
Pattern Recognition				
Problem-Solving				
Open-Mindedness				
Self-Reflection				
Decision-Making Under Uncertainty				

Competence - Personality Types

Personality Types (DICS) model



<https://wundertraining.com.au/communication-masterclass/>



Style	Challenges	Best Way to Communicate
Dominance (D)	Can be impatient , blunt, or overbearing.	Be direct , brief, and focus on results. Avoid rambling.
Influence (I)	May lose track of details or overcommit.	Be enthusiastic, friendly, and allow time for socializing.
Steadiness (S)	Struggles with sudden change or conflict.	Be patient, supportive , and provide clear step-by-step plans.
Cautious (C)	Can get bogged down in data or overanalyse .	Be factual, accurate , and give them time to think.

Activity: Building Team Self-Awareness 😊

Step1: Individual Assessment:[10 min]

Rate how much you identify with each DISC style on a scale from 1 (Low) to 5 (High)

👎

1

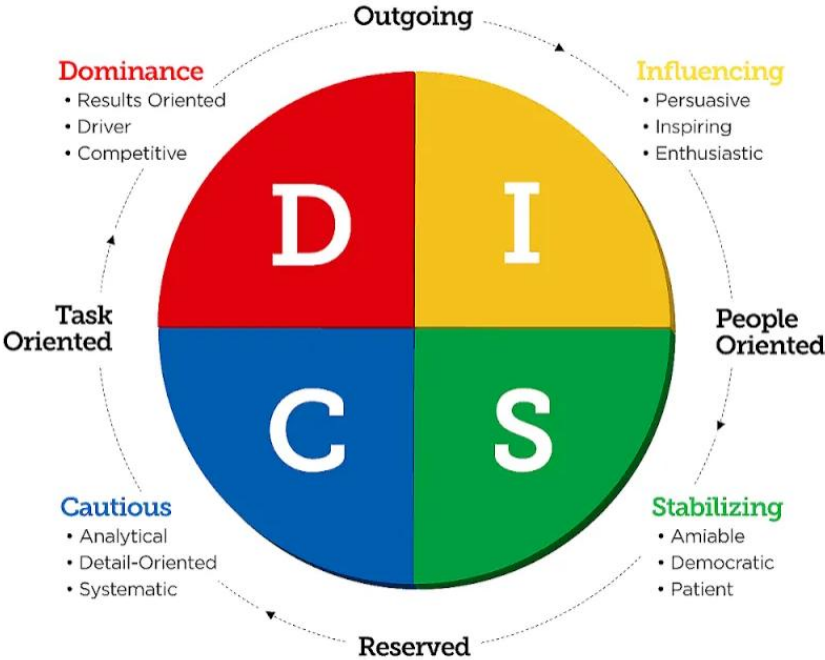
2

3

4

5

👍



Step2: Team Discussion [15 mins]:

Compare your scores.

Where do our strengths align, and where do our communication styles clash?

Style	Assessment	What frustrates me?	How to work with me?
Dominance			
Influence			
Steadiness			
Cautious			

A low-angle, blue-tinted photograph of a group of graduates in black gowns. They are all looking upwards with expressions of joy and excitement, their arms raised. Several black graduation caps are captured mid-air, having just been tossed. The background is a bright, clear sky.

Learned Lessons

The Four work Styles



LOGICAL

The action takers. They like a challenge and thrive when analyzing data and working with facts.

SUPPORTIVE

Fosters positive relationships with everyone and works best in groups.



IDEA ORIENTED

The innovators. They look at the big picture to help the company achieve its goals.

DETAIL ORIENTED

Great attention to detail, planning, and preparation skills. Nothing is overlooked with this work style.



<https://atassist.com/blog/what-are-the-four-work-styles-learn-more-about-your-teams-approach-to-work>



Work Style	Challenges (Potential Pitfalls)	Best Way to Communicate with
Logical	Can come across as cold ; may disregard emotional or human factors.	Stick to the facts , present data clearly , and skip overly emotional appeals.
Supportive	May avoid necessary conflict ; can struggle to voice unpopular opinions.	Be collaborative , warm, and show how decisions affect the team as individuals.
Idea-Oriented	Might lose focus on the finer details; can struggle with practical follow-through .	Keep it big-picture , encourage creativity , and don't instantly shut down wild ideas.
Detail-Oriented	Can suffer from " analysis paralysis "; may resist sudden changes to plans.	Provide explicit instructions, allow plenty of time for preparation , and be highly structured.

Let us experience some Self Awareness 😊

Step 1: Individual Rating :

How much do you identify with each work style? Rate from 1 (Low) to 5 (High).

👎

1

2

3

4

5

👍

Step2: Team Discussion:

Compare your profiles.

How do our different styles create **balance** or cause **friction**? [15 mins]



Work Style	Assessment	What slows me down?	How to Communicate to me?
Logical			
Supportive			
Idea-Oriented			
Detail-Oriented			

A low-angle, blue-tinted photograph of a group of graduates in black gowns. They are all looking upwards with expressions of joy and excitement, their arms raised. Several black graduation caps are captured mid-air, having just been tossed. The background is a bright, clear sky.

Learned Lessons

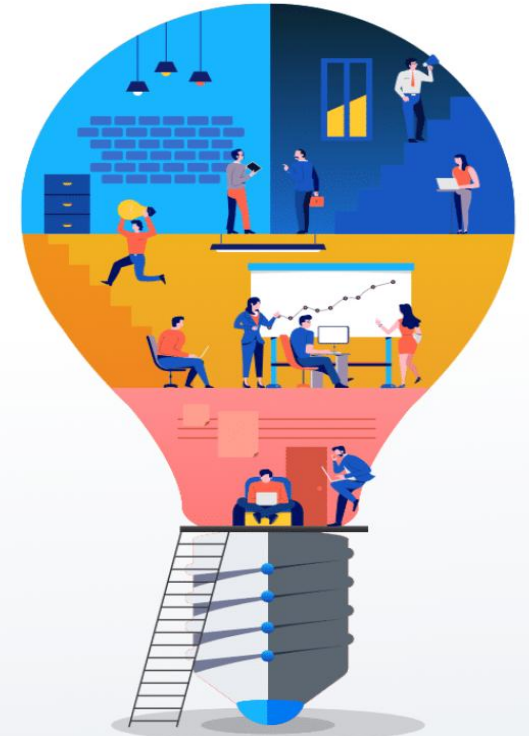
Communication in Intercultural and Heterogeneous teams

Objectives

- Understand the **cultural values foundations** of intercultural communication
- Identify common **challenges** in heterogeneous teams
- Apply **strategic** models for effective communication
- Practice communication skills through exercises

Communication Strategies in Intercultural and Heterogeneous Teams

Strategic Approaches for **Diverse Work Environments**

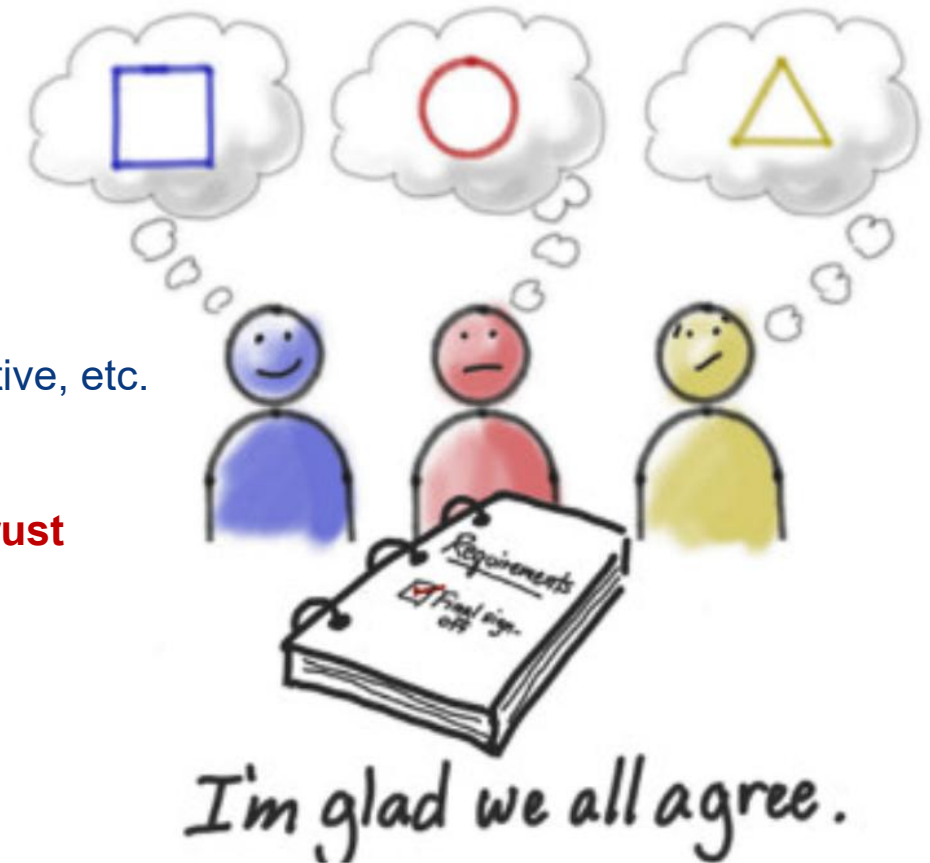


<https://www.sociabble.com/blog/employee-communications/what-is-a-communication-strategy/>

- **Communication** is more than **information exchange** – it's about **shared understanding**
- **Heterogeneous** teams = **diversity** in culture, functional background, demographic, cognitive, etc.
- **Strategic** communication reduces **misunderstandings** and **builds trust**

Key elements:

- ❑ **Verbal**: language, tone, speed
- ❑ **Non-verbal**: gestures, eye contact, silence



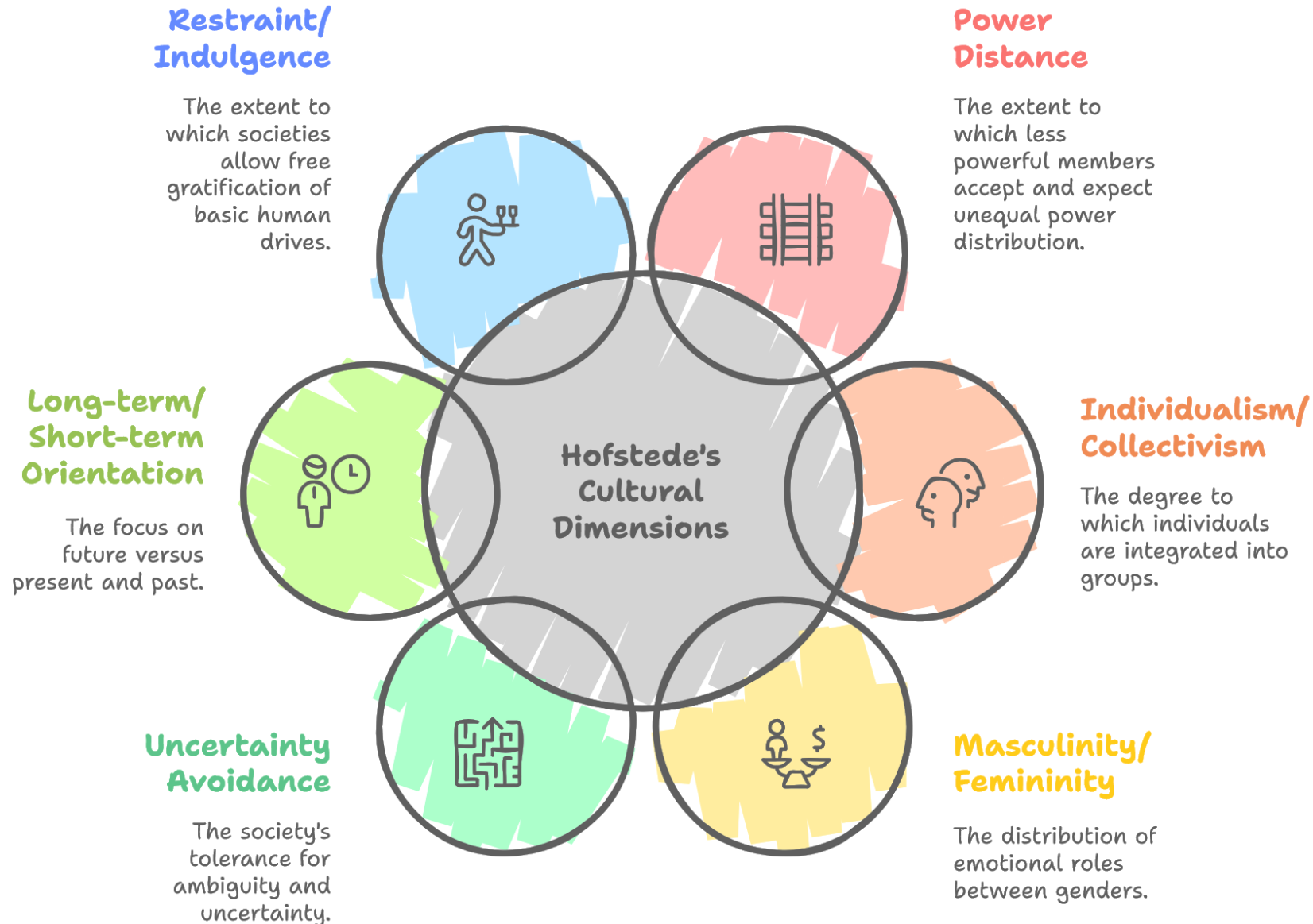
Jeff Patton :<http://jpattonassociates.com/>

Cultural frameworks:

☐ Hofstede's **Dimensions**

☐ Hall's High/Low **Context**

Hofstede's Cultural Framework





It describes how **comfortable people** are with **hierarchy** and **unequal power** in a **group** or **society**.

High Power Distance cultures:

- **Strong hierarchy**: Subordinates expect to be told what to do.
- **Status and authority** are **respected** without question.

Examples: Malaysia, Mexico, China, many Arab countries

In teams: Employees **may not question** leaders, and **decisions** are usually **top-down**.

Low Power Distance cultures:

- **Preference for equality**: Subordinates and leaders often interact as **equals**.
- **Open communication** between **levels** of authority.

Examples: Denmark, Sweden, New Zealand, the Netherlands

In teams: Employees **speak up, challenge** ideas, and leaders often **involve** teams in decision-making.

Individualism vs. Collectivism

It describes how people **relate** to the **group** they **belong** to and how they **prioritize personal** goals versus **group** goals.

Individualism

- People see themselves as independent individuals.
- Personal achievements and rights are emphasized.
- Responsibility is individual (e.g., “I am responsible for...”).

Examples: USA, UK, Canada, Australia

In teams:

- Members prefer autonomy.
- **Direct** communication is common.
- Tasks are prioritized over relationships.



Collectivism

- People see themselves as part of a group (family, team, community).
- Group goals, harmony, and loyalty are emphasized.
- Responsibility is shared (e.g., “We are responsible for...”).

Examples: China, India, Japan, Colombia

In teams:

- Group consensus is important.
- **Indirect** communication may be used to preserve harmony.
- Relationships are prioritized over tasks.

Uncertainty Avoidance

It reflects how **comfortable** a group is with **ambiguity, risk, and the unknown.**

High Uncertainty Avoidance

- People **prefer rules, structure**, and predictability.
- Innovation may be resisted if it brings too much change.
- Formal procedures and detailed planning are important.

Examples: Germany, Japan, Portugal, South Korea

In teams:

- Prefer clear instructions and well-defined roles.
- Risk-averse; change is carefully managed.
- Unclear goals or tasks may cause stress.



Low Uncertainty Avoidance

- People are more comfortable with **ambiguity** and **change**.
- Flexibility, experimentation, and improvisation are valued.
- Fewer rules; informal communication is common.

Examples: Singapore, Sweden, UK, India,...

In teams:

- Tolerant of different approaches.
- Open to innovation and new ideas.
- Can work effectively with minimal guidelines.

Long-Term vs. Short-Term Orientation

It reflects how societies/groups prioritize
future rewards versus present values.

Long-Term Orientation (LTO)

- Focus on **future goals**, perseverance, and **sustained** efforts.
- Values such as **thrift, saving, and adaptability** are emphasized.
- Truth is viewed as **relative** and **context-dependent**.

Examples: China, Japan, South Korea, Germany..

In teams:

- Strategic, long-range planning is favored.
- Patience with long-term projects.
- High value on learning, growth, and adaptability.

Short-Term Orientation (STO)

- Focus on past and present, **tradition**, and fulfilling **social** obligations.
- Values such as **respect for tradition, saving face, and quick results** are emphasized.
- **Truth** is seen as **absolute** and **universal**.

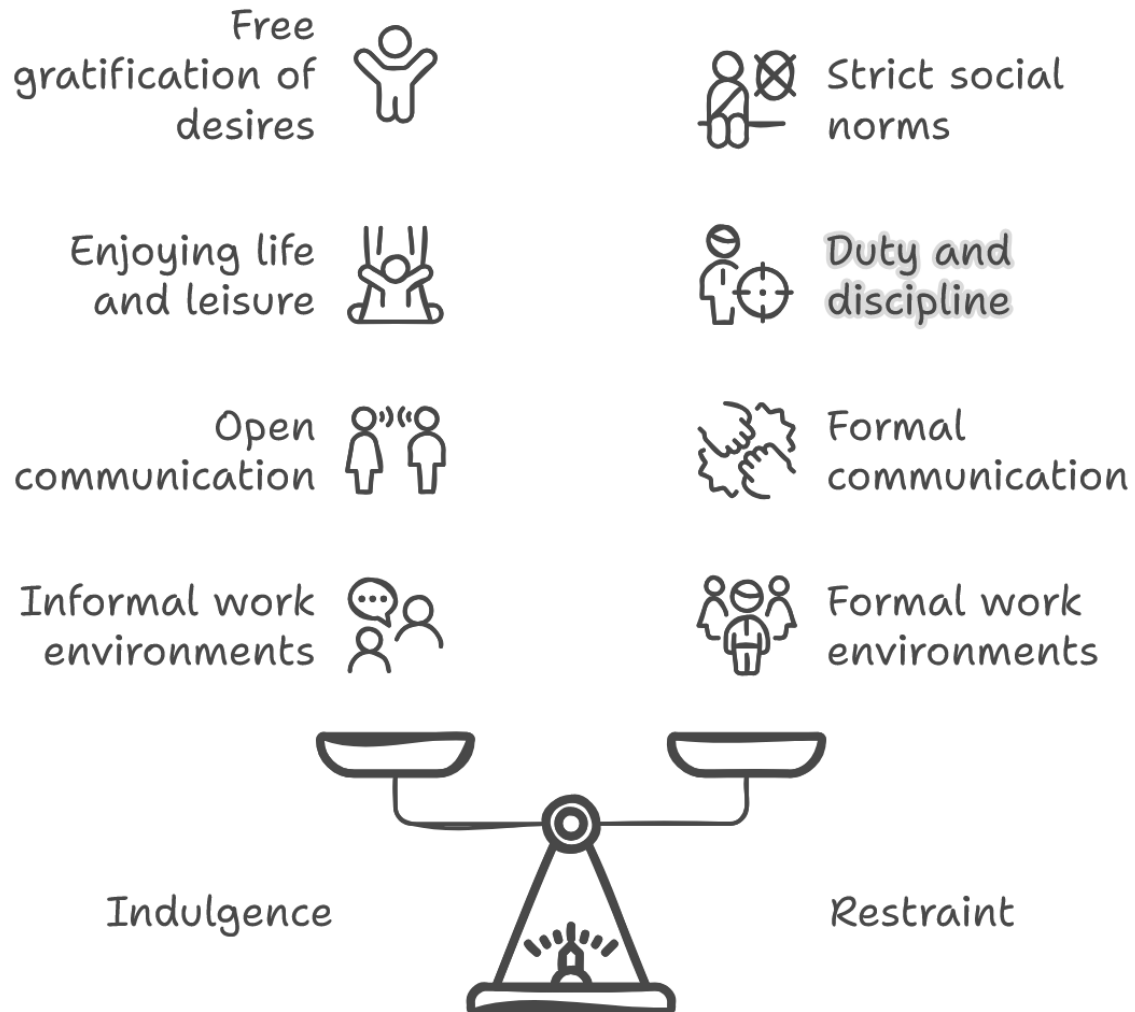
Examples: USA, UK, Nigeria, Philippines, ...

In teams:

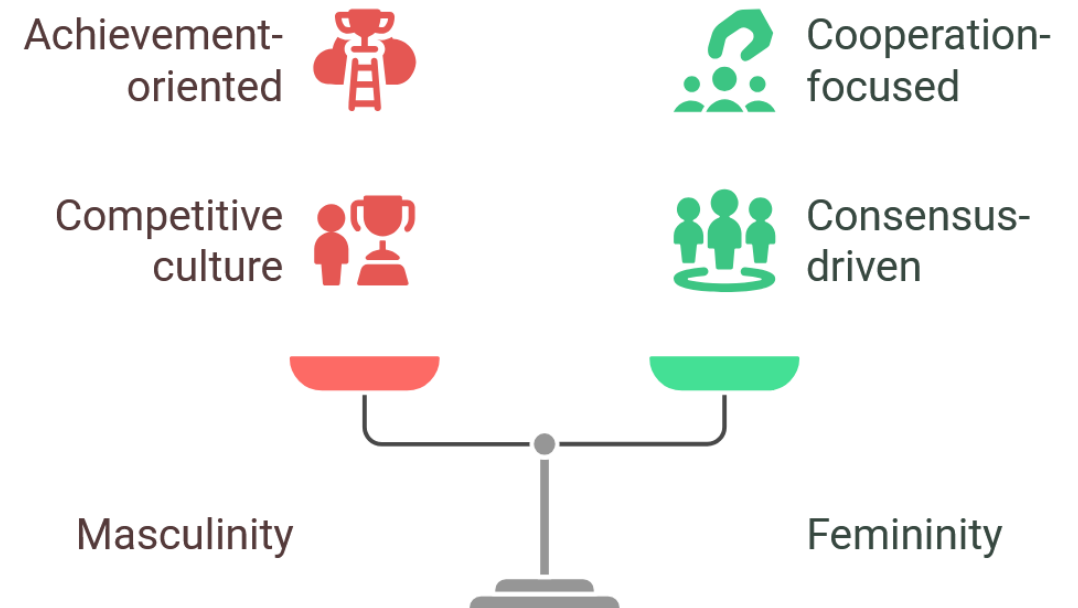
- Quick wins and efficiency are prioritized.
- Decisions may be made for short-term benefit.
- Emphasis on immediate results and performance.

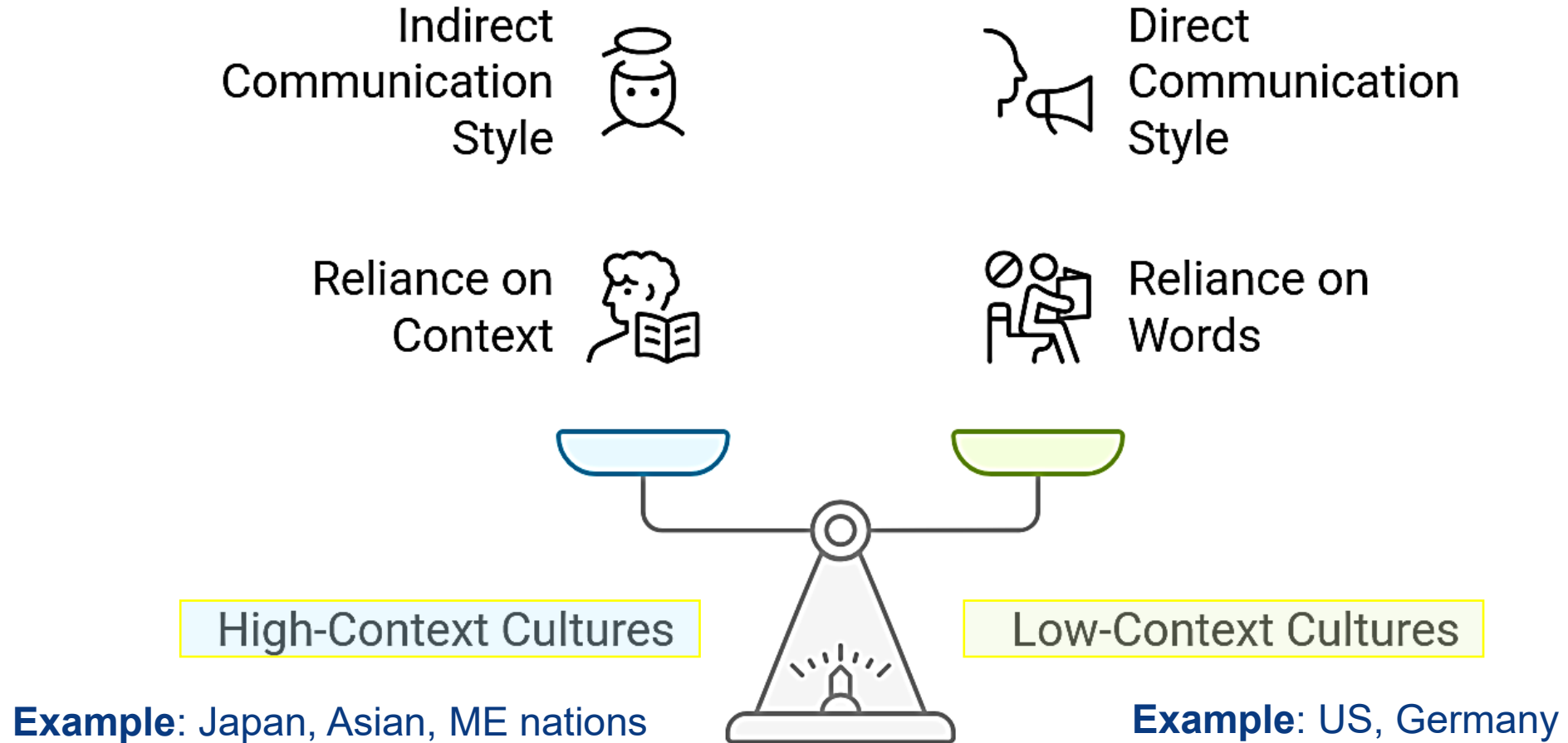


Comparing Indulgence and Restraint in Societies



Balancing Societal Values in Masculinity and Femininity







Barriers!

Common Barriers in Diverse Teams

- **Language** and **proficiency** gaps



Language Proficiency

Differences in language skills can create bias.

- **Accent** and **dialect** bias



Accent Bias

Prejudice based on how someone pronounces words.

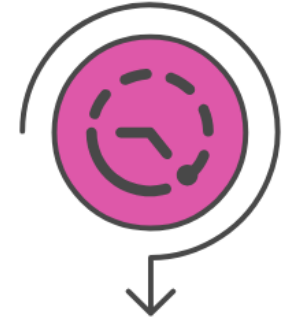
- **Stereotypes** and implicit bias



Stereotypes Bias

Preconceived notions influencing judgment and actions.

- **Time** perception and **work styles**



Time Work Styles

Varying approaches to deadlines and task management.

Identified Barrier Category	Specific Team Example / Scenario	How it may impact collaboration?
Language Proficiency	<i>e.g., Team members staying quiet in meetings because they are afraid of making grammatical errors.</i>	<i>Missed ideas, uneven distribution of work, and hidden frustration.</i>
Accent Bias	<i>e.g., Unconsciously valuing an idea less because it was spoken with a heavy regional accent.</i>	<i>Loss of valuable expertise and subtle exclusion.</i>
Stereotypes Bias	<i>e.g., Assuming a team member from a specific culture will automatically be passive or aggressive.</i>	<i>Misjudging capabilities and creating interpersonal tension.</i>
Time & Work Styles	<i>e.g., Clashing over deadlines because some cultures treat time flexibly while others are hyper-rigid.</i>	<i>Missed project deadlines and broken professional trust.</i>

Exercise : Barrier Identification

Group 3-6 students



Language Proficiency
Differences in language skills can create bias.



Accent Bias
Prejudice based on how someone pronounces words.



Stereotypes Bias
Preconceived notions influencing judgment and actions.



Time Work Styles
Varying approaches to deadlines and task management.

Descriptions:

- **Step1: Individual [5-10 mins]:**
Reflect on diverse teams you have worked in.
Note down the **top 3 communication barriers** you have personally **experienced** or **observed**.
- **Step2: Group work [10 mins]:** Compare your notes and select your team's **top 3 collective barriers**.
Flesh them out with concrete **real-world examples or scenarios**.
- **Ready** to share your **list** with the **whole** group.

Identified Barrier Category	Specific Team Example / Scenario	How it may impact collaboration?
Language Proficiency		
Accent Bias		
Stereotypes Bias		
Time & Work Styles		

General Communication Styles

Why is it Important?

Exercise : **The Paper Folding Challenge**



- **Duration:** 5-10 minutes (each)
- **Setup:**
 - **Two people** sit back-to-back.
 - Each person has a **blank A4** sheet of paper.
 - **Person A** will be the **instructor**, and **Person B** will be the **follower**.
 - **Person A** is given a **secret “paper design”** (a simple series of **folds or tears**, described in text form).
 - **Person B** must try to replicate Person A’s design **by only listening to instructions** (no looking, no gestures).
- **Rules:**
 - Person A must not look at Person B.
 - Person A **cannot say “like I’m doing”** or give **visual** cues.
 - Person B **cannot ask questions** unless allowed in variation rounds.

Variations:

- **Round 2:** Allow **Person B** to ask clarifying **questions**.
- **Round 3:** they can **face each other** but still only use words (no gestures).
- **Round 4:** Switch roles.

Exercise : Putting on a Jacket instructions rain poncho

- **Duration:** 10 minutes
- **Setup:**
 - **Two people** stand back-to-back, one has a **Jacket**.
 - **Person A** will be the **instructor**, and **Person B** will be the **follower**.
 - **Person A** gives the instructions to put on the **Jacket**.
 - **Person B** must follow the instructions **EXACTLY** by only listening to instructions (no looking, no gestures).
- **Rules:**
 - Person A must not look at Person B.
 - Person A **cannot say “like I’m doing”** or give **visual** cues.
 - Person B can/**cannot ask questions** unless allowed in variation rounds.



Variations:

- **Round 2:** Allow **Person B** to ask clarifying **questions**.
- **Round 3:** Switch roles.

General Communication Styles

Direct Communication

- Message is **stated clearly** and **explicitly**
- Common in **low-context** cultures (e.g., U.S., Germany)
- **Prioritizes** clarity and efficiency

Example: “I disagree with your idea.”

Indirect Communication

- Message is **implied, suggested, or hinted at**
- Common in **high-context** cultures (e.g., Japan, India, UK sometimes)
- Prioritizes **politeness, harmony**, and context

Example: “That’s an interesting idea, **but** maybe we could also consider...”



In teams: **Direct** styles may seem **rude** to **indirect** speakers;
indirect styles may seem **vague** to **direct** speakers..

General Communication Styles

Formal Communication

- Polite, structured, and often uses titles
- Used in hierarchical **or high power distance cultures** (e.g., Korea, France)
- Communication follows roles and status

Example: “Dear Mr. Tanaka, I hope this message finds you well.”

Informal Communication

- **Casual**, relaxed, and may use first names
- Common in **low power distance** cultures (e.g., Australia, Netherlands)
- Communication is based on familiarity or comfort

Example: “Hey Kenji! Just checking in—how’s it going?”

In teams: **Informal** styles may seem **disrespectful** to **formal** cultures;
formality may seem **distant** to **informal** cultures.



General Communication Styles

Verbal Communication

- Face-to-face, phone, video, spoken
- Allows **immediate** feedback
- **Emphasizes tone**, body language

Common in oral-tradition or **relationship-based** cultures

Written Communication

- Emails, memos, reports, chat
- Offers clarity, documentation, and record-keeping
- Emphasizes **clarity** and **correctness**

Common in **task-based**, legalistic, or **documentation-heavy** cultures

In **teams**: Some cultures prefer **talking** to solve problems;
others prefer **emails** to avoid **misinterpretation**.



General Communication Styles

High-Context Communication

- Relies on **shared** background, **nonverbal** cues
- Much is “**unsaid**” — meaning is in the **context**
- **Relationship-oriented**

Common in East Asia, Arab world, Latin America

Low-Context Communication

- Relies on **explicit**, detailed information
- Everything **important** is **said directly** in words
- **Task-** or **result-oriented**

Common in Germany, Scandinavia, North America

In teams: **High-context** communicators may expect others to “**read between the lines**”;
low-context communicators may expect others to “**say what they mean.**”



Discover Your Communication Style



Goal: Understand how different styles influence teamwork.

Instructions:

1. **Individual work:** which of the communication styles applies to you more.
Support your choices with examples [5 mins]

- Direct / Indirect
- Formal / Informal
- Verbal / Written
- High-context / Low-context

2. Build a **team communication profile (Support your choices with examples) [10 mins]**

3. Discuss your results – with others **[15 mins]**



A low-angle, blue-tinted photograph of a group of graduates in black gowns. They are all looking upwards with expressions of joy and excitement, their arms raised high. Several black graduation caps are captured mid-air, having just been tossed by the graduates. The background is a bright, clear sky.

Communication Exercises

Exercise : **The Paper Folding Challenge**



- **Duration:** 10 minutes (each)
- **Setup:**
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 - Each person has a **blank A4** sheet of paper.
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Variations:

- **Round 2: Allow Person B to ask clarifying questions.**
- **Round 3: Let them face each other** but still only use words (no gestures).
- **Round 4: Switch roles.**

Exercise : Putting on a Jacket instructions



- **Duration:** 10 minutes
- **Setup:**
 - **Two people** stand back-to-back, one has a **Jacket**.
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 - **Person A** gives the instructions to put on the **Jacket**.
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- **Rules:**
 - Person A must not look at Person B.
 - Person A **cannot say “like I’m doing”** or give **visual** cues.
 - Person B can/**cannot ask questions** unless allowed in variation rounds.



Variations:

- **Round 2:** Allow **Person B** to ask clarifying **questions**.
- **Round 3:** Switch roles.

Exercise : Paraphrase Practice



- **Duration:** 5 minutes
- **Pair up participants.**
- **Instructions:**
 - **Person A** explains a **simple** process or idea (e.g., **how to order office supplies**). [3 mins]
 - **Person B** **listens** carefully and **then paraphrases** what they **heard** in their own words. [3-5 mins]
 - **Person A** **confirms** or **corrects** the paraphrase.
 - **Swap roles** and repeat with a new idea.



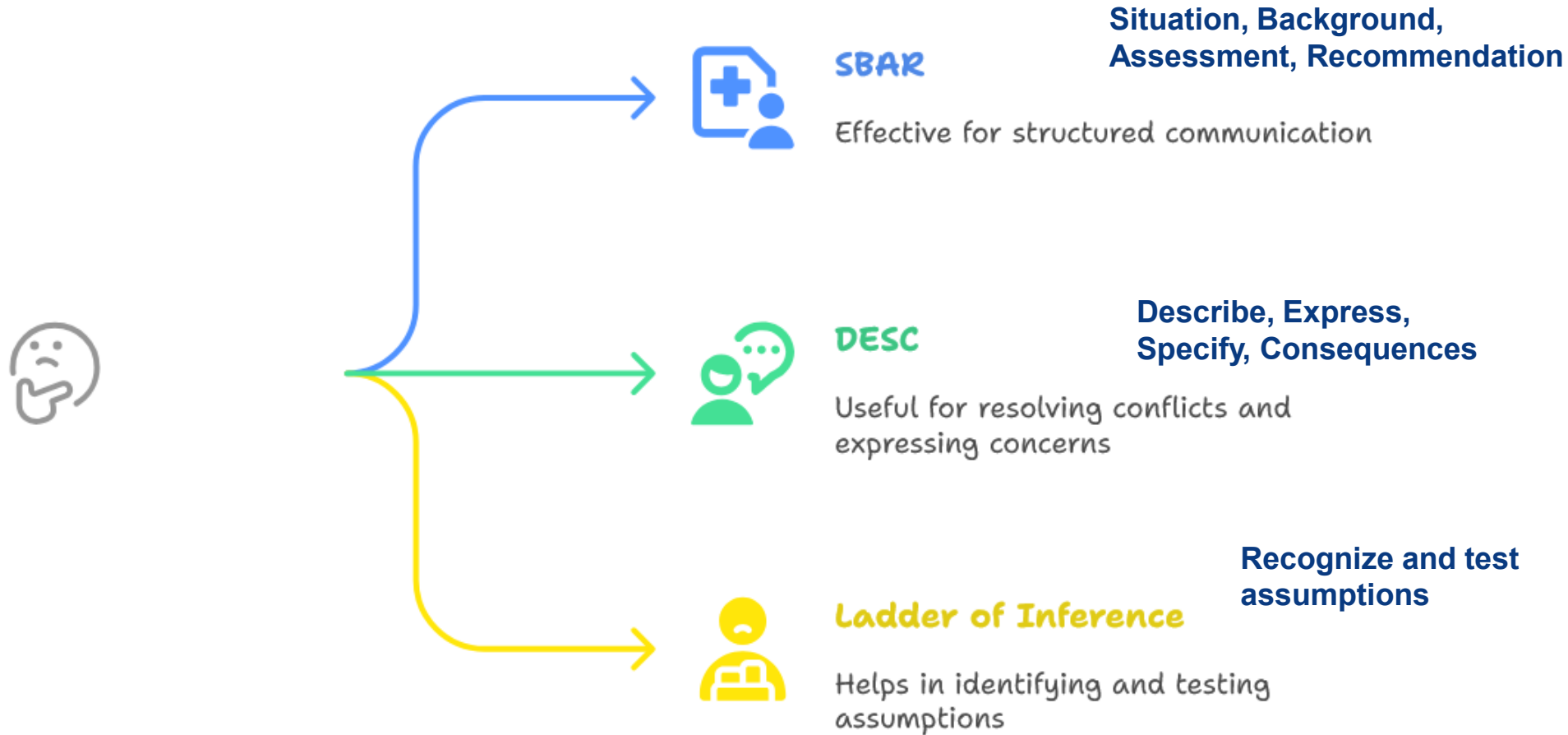
Objective of the exercises:

To highlight the importance of
clear communication,
active listening, and
interpreting instructions accurately.

Learned Lessons

A low-angle, blue-tinted photograph of a group of graduates in black gowns. They are all looking upwards with expressions of joy and excitement, their arms raised. Several black graduation caps are captured mid-air, having just been tossed. The background is a bright, clear sky.

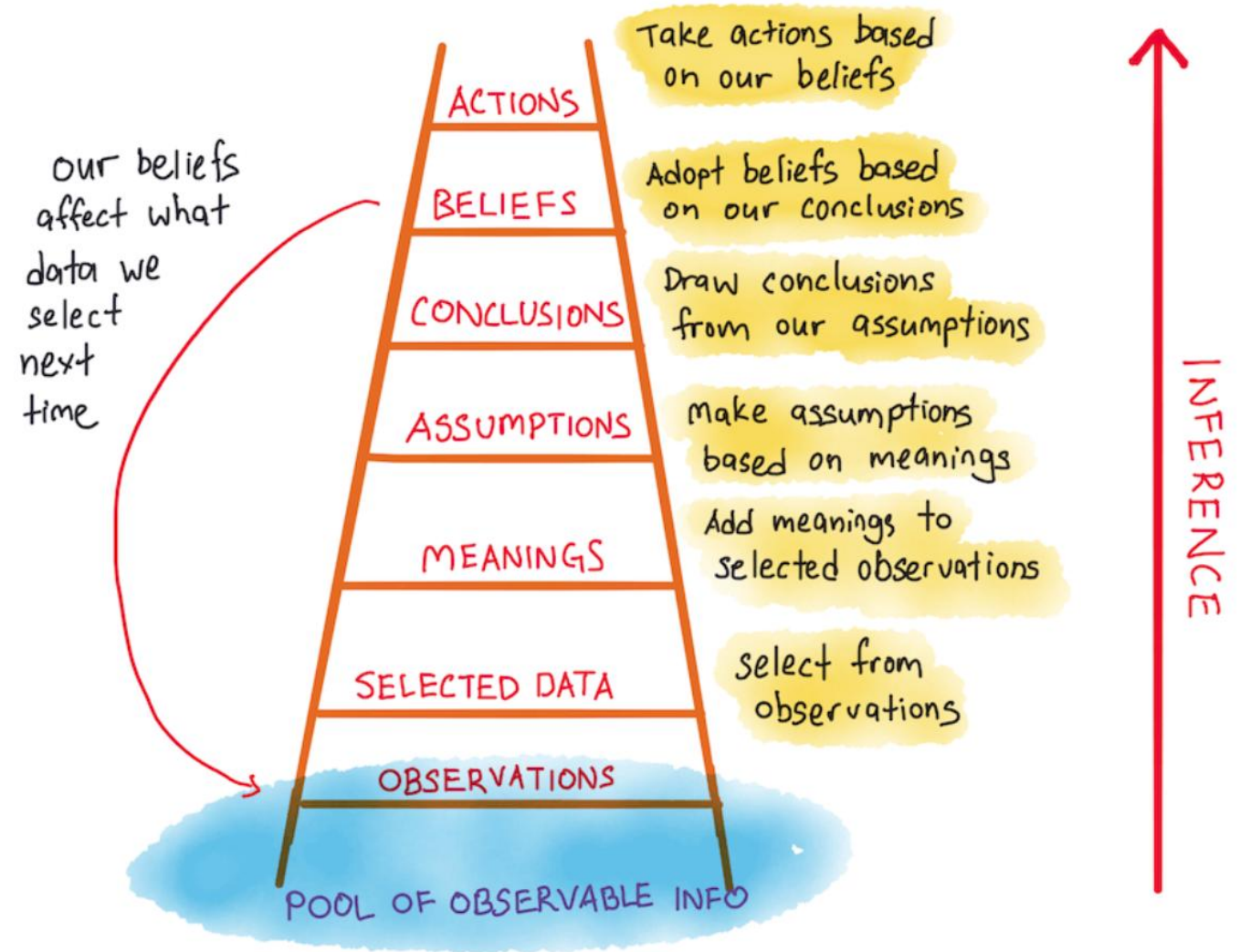
Communication Models



Ladder of inference

how people **move** from **observable facts** to **actions**
based on **assumptions and beliefs**

often without realizing it.



<https://www.holistics.io/blog/ladder-of-inference-communicating-analytics/>

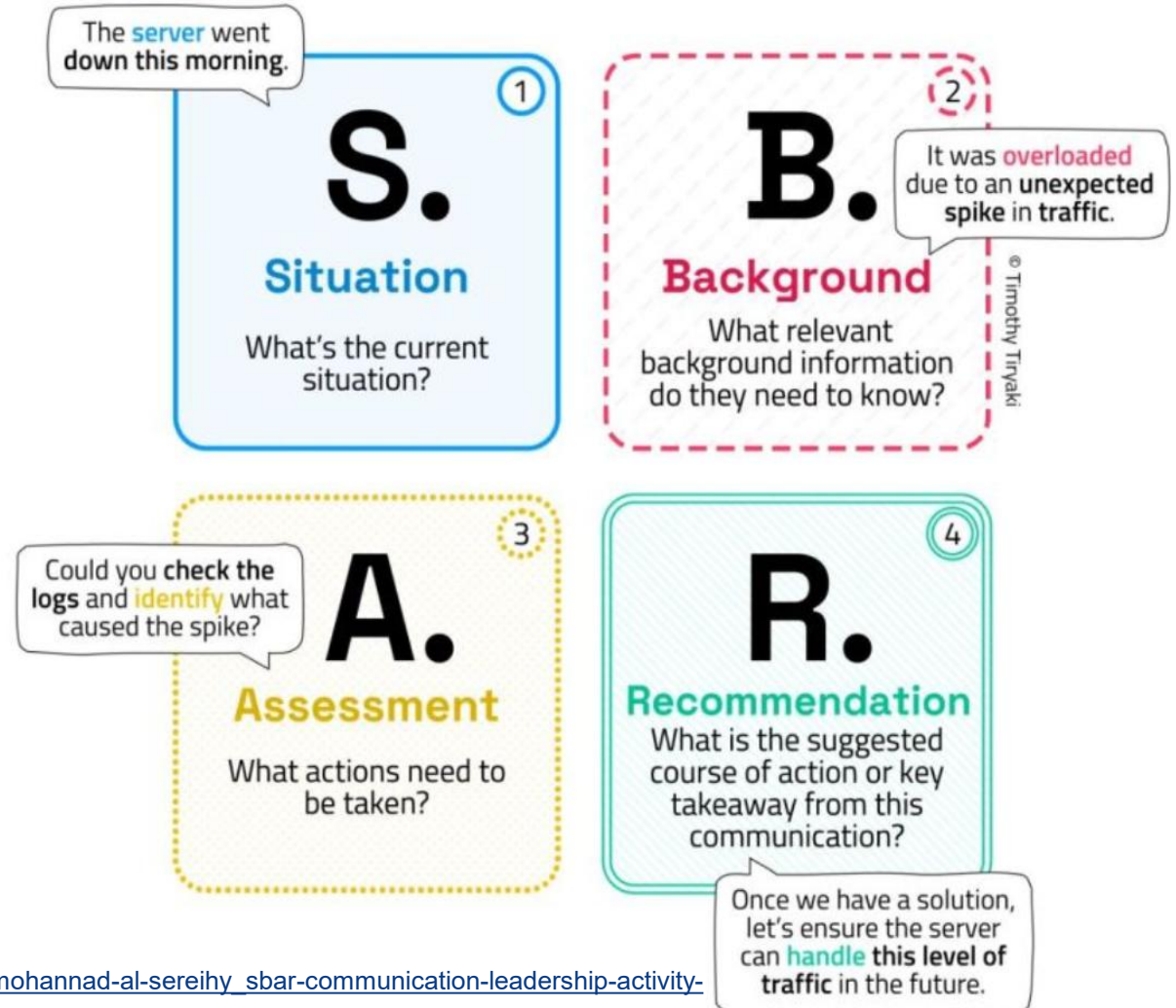
THINKING |
INDUSTRY NEW

SBAR Model Example

- ❑ **Situation:** Project is behind schedule
- ❑ **Background:** Designer was ill, visuals incomplete
- ❑ **Assessment:** Risk of under-delivery
- ❑ **Recommendation:** Extend deadline or bring support

The SBAR Technique

A Practical Tool for Clarity in Communication



https://www.linkedin.com/posts/mohannad-al-sereihy_sbar-communication-leadership-activity-7263509294614990848-lfms/

- ❑ **Describe:** "You missed the last two deadlines."
- ❑ **Express:** "I feel concerned about the impact on the team."
- ❑ **Specify:** "Please inform me earlier if delays occur."
- ❑ **Consequences:** "We can adjust timelines proactively."



Strategic Tactics for Communication



Communication Tactics



Plain Language

Use simple and easily understandable language in your communications. This ensures clarity and reduces the chances of misinterpretation.

Rephrase the message in your own words and repeat key points. This reinforces understanding and confirms accuracy.

Paraphrase and Repeat



Clarifying Questions

Ask questions to ensure you fully understand the information. This helps to address any ambiguities or uncertainties.

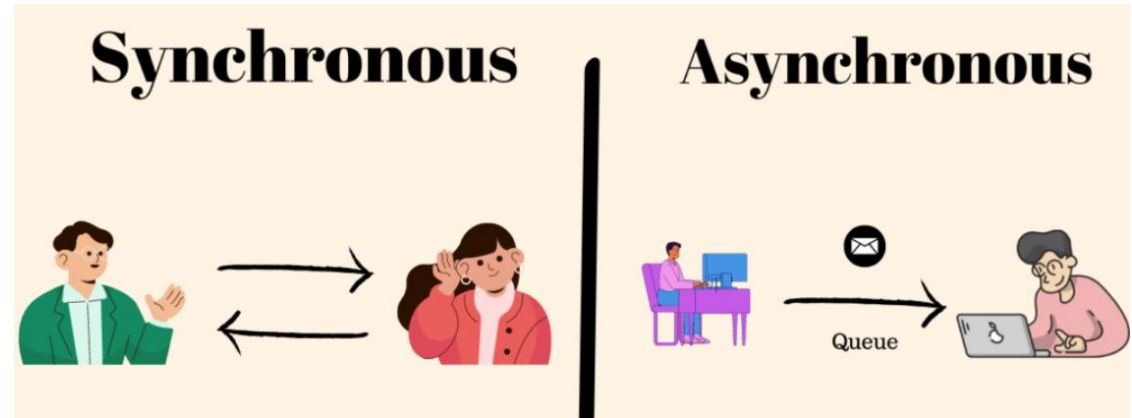
Incorporate visuals and shared documents to support your message. This provides context and enhances comprehension.

Visuals and Documents



Psychological Safety

Create an environment where people feel comfortable sharing ideas. This encourages open communication and collaboration.



- ❑ **Synchronous:** meetings, calls (good for interactive/ emotional topics)
- ❑ **Asynchronous:** email, platforms (good for documentation)

Match the message to the medium



Exercise Active Listening

Listen with Intent [10 mins]

Goal: Build empathy and **sharpen listening** skills.

Instructions: Pairs of students

1. **Partner A** speaks for **3 minutes** about a **team experience**.

2. **Partner B** listens actively:

- Maintain **eye** contact
- Avoid **interruptions**
- **Summarize** message & tone **[5 mins]**

3. **Switch roles.**



Case Study: Intercultural Team Conflict

Case Study: Intercultural Team Conflict



The Setup: An Intercultural project-team consisting of members from Brazil, India, and Germany is working on a **critical** software release.

The Incident: The team has just missed a major project milestone.

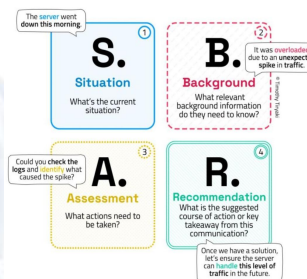
The Conflict:

- The **German** team members feel the Brazilian team is **too relaxed** about timelines and lacks structure.
- The **Brazilian** team members feel the German team is **overly rigid**, and creates unnecessary friction.
- The **Indian** team members are trying to stay supportive but are **hesitant** to voice their concerns openly to avoid worsening the conflict.

→ Pick one Tool **SBAR** or **DESC**, and describe/analyze the approach to **resolve the issue**

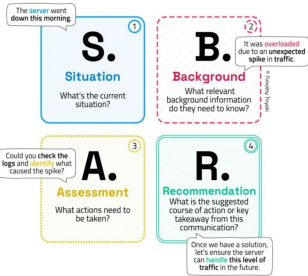
The SBAR Technique

A Practical Tool for Clarity in Communication



Option A: The SBAR Approach (Best for a formal status update/escalation)

If your choose **SBAR**, you can use this table structure to communicate the problem and the proposed solution t stakeholder.



Element	Focus Question	Team's Application / Resolution
Situation	What is the immediate crisis right now?	e.g., We missed our project milestone due to fundamental communication breakdowns regarding deadline expectations.
Background	What context led up to this point?	e.g., The team consists of members from Brazil, India, and Germany who are working with differing cultural approaches to time management and feedback styles.
Assessment	What do you think the core issue is?	e.g., The root issue isn't a lack of skill, but an unaligned workflow and mismanaged communication expectations between rigid vs. flexible working styles.
Recommendation	What is the explicit action plan to fix it?	e.g., Implement a clear RACI matrix, host a team-alignment session to define standard communication protocols, and schedule weekly syncs.



Option B: The DESC Approach (Best for direct, interpersonal conflict resolution)

If you choose **DESC**, you can use this table to **script** a **direct conversation** with a conflicting **team member** to resolve the tension.

Element	Focus Question	Team's Script / Action
Describe	<i>What is the objective, fact-based behaviour observed?</i>	<i>e.g., "In our last project phase, deadlines were missed twice without prior notification, which delayed the subsequent development phases."</i>
Express	<i>How does this impact the team and the business?</i>	<i>e.g., "This creates anxiety within the team, causes internal friction, and puts our client delivery date at high risk."</i>
Suggest	<i>What concrete, actionable alternative is required?</i>	<i>e.g., "Moving forward, if a task looks like it will run late, let's agree to flag it at least 48 hours in advance so we can adapt together."</i>
Consequences	<i>What are the positive outcomes if this is resolved?</i>	<i>e.g., "This will rebuild trust across our global team, reduce stress, and ensure we hit our final release smoothly."</i>

- My personality type → **communication style** are ...
- In a diverse team, I need to remember...
- **One strategy** I will try is...



Exercises and assessments are recommended to be revisited
frequently throughout the career development life-time 😊

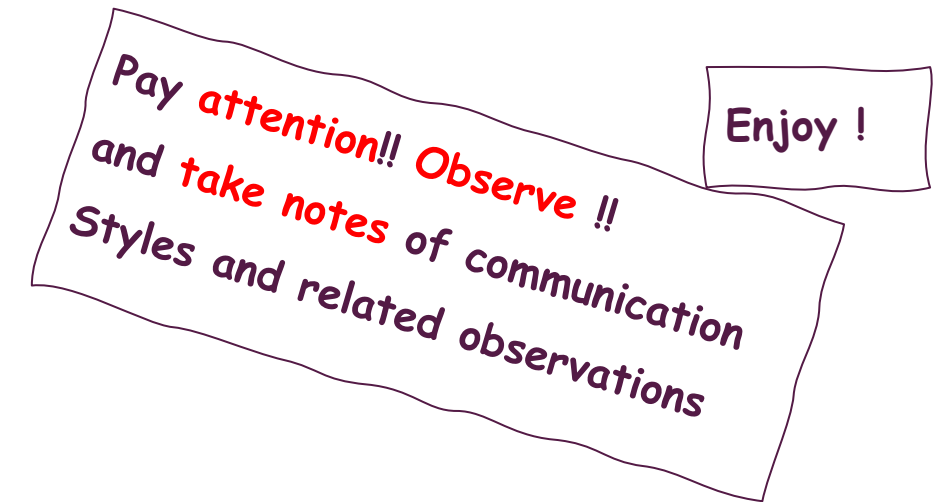
They are not only for one time experience!

- **Communication in Multicultural Teams: 6 Steps to Make it Work | Be an Effective Communicator**

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=w8iE1_EbSqc

- **Cross cultural communication | Pellegrino Riccardi | TEDxBergen**

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=YMyofREc5Jk>



Recommended Readings

- Hofstede, G. (2001). **Culture's Consequences: Comparing Values, Behaviors, Institutions, and Organizations Across Nations.** Second Edition, Thousand Oaks CA: Sage Publications.